Games Made Elsewhere, Harms Felt Here: A Speculative Perspective of Deceptive Design Impact from the Global South

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Abstract

This paper uses a speculative design scenario to critique the unequal power dynamics in global games. It argues that Deceptive Patterns may function as tools of exploitation, not just manipulation, when applied to players in the Global South. The work introduces the creator-consumer divide and calls for equitable collaborations to confront this emerging form of digital harm.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **HCI theory, concepts and models**; • **Social and professional topics** → **Geographic characteristics**; *Privacy policies*; • **General and reference** → Reference works.

Keywords

Human-Computer Interaction, Video Games, Creator-Consumer Divide, Deceptive Patterns, Dark Patterns, Global South, Speculative Design, Decoloniality, Regulatory Arbitrage, Predatory Monetization, Systemic Vulnerability, WEIRD

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1 Introduction

As a researcher from Brazil, and part of the diverse and complex makeup often referred to as the "Global South," I continually reflect on how global research results correspond to our local realities. Especially in games. Brazil is Latin America's largest games market (103 million players [33]). Yet, our global contribution to game development and research is inconsistent with that data. Brazil has a very active Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) community, with a 24-edition national symposium (IHC) and recent Grand Challenges [25] tailored to our reality. However, there are minimal funding opportunities for games and play research from the HCI perspective, as other national priorities take precedence, and a young, small-scale, and export-oriented domestic game industry [4]. This positions us, like many other non-high-income countries (e.g., India, where global publishers often run only support operations [5]), primarily **consumers of games made elsewhere**.

The most popular mobile games in Brazil (and India!), e.g., *Free Fire*, *Roblox*, *Candy Crush Saga* [1, 2] are not only from overseas, but filled with Deceptive Patterns (DPs) [30]. DPs, formerly known as Dark Patterns [6], are manipulative designs exploiting user biases for commercial gain at the user's expense. In games, they are intensified by the industry's shift to "predatory monetization," obscuring true costs [27]. They can cause several harms [7, 23, 24], and potentially worsen Gaming Disorder (GD) [32, 37]. Yes, games are also full of DPs in **W**estern, **E**ducated, **I**ndustrialized, **R**ich, and **D**emocratic (WEIRD) contexts. Digital exploitation is not geographically exclusive. The central question is therefore not if harm occurs elsewhere, but: *Do the vast differences in non-WEIRD contexts alter the nature and magnitude of that harm?* While players in WEIRD countries, where most of these games are developed, face risks, this paper argues that the harm can be systemically amplified in major Global South markets.

2 The Creator-Consumer Divide as a Lens for Understanding Systemic Player Vulnerability

This paper proposes the **creator-consumer divide** as a theoretical construct: a structural schism between creation and consumption contexts, where vulnerabilities are systemic, pre-existing, and capitalized upon via deliberate targeting or indifferent automation. The divide has two nuances.

First, games as entertainment can lower players' critical guard [36], making them more susceptible to manipulative designs disguised as 'part of the game.' This effect is amplified when a significant portion of the population lacks fundamental cognitive defenses, a vulnerability stemming from deep-seated societal issues in the Global South. The contrast between the United States (US) and Brazil illustrates this asymmetry. The US poverty rate is 11.1% [31], while in Brazil it is over double at 27.4% [14], indicating a more widespread precarity, which is linked to stress-impaired decision-making [16]. A paradox of high digital penetration (86.2% [8]) coexisting with low functional literacy amplifies the situation. While the US grapples with a substantial illiteracy rate affecting 18% of its adults, a challenge concentrated mainly in specific minority and low-income groups [26], Brazil's issue is more pervasive. 29% of Brazilians are functionally illiterate (stagnant since 2018), with another 36% possessing only elementary literacy skills [19, 20]. It suggests that over half the population may struggle with the critical thinking skills [34] necessary to defend against manipulative practices and discourses. This national-scale vulnerability is distinct from the challenges within specific US communities. Cultural

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particularities, such as authority norms, can compound these vulnerabilities, creating additional exploitation vectors that are also likely distinct from the creator's context.

Second, the power imbalance operates structurally through regulatory arbitrage, exploiting political contexts that, often due to economic pressures, lack strong and enforceable consumer protection. Less stringent consumer protection frameworks in many Global South markets permit the deployment of systems and monetization models that would face greater scrutiny or be prohibited in other regions, such as the European Union (EU), where cooperation networks work to enhance consumer protection when playing video games. For instance, while EU principles demand transparent pricing and respect for consumer vulnerabilities in online gaming [35], their absence in Brazil, as well as in other countries in the Global South, means that models can systematically obscure true costs, deny consumers the withdrawal right, and intentionally target the most vulnerable players without facing similar legal repercussions.

So, to what extent does our current game and DP knowledge apply to non-WEIRD contexts, as research in this topic originates predominantly from WEIRD contexts [18] (e.g., [11, 13, 15, 22, 29])? This bias, mirrored in psychology (where WEIRD populations are 12% globally but dominate studies [17]) and broad HCI research [21], limits findings' external validity for the global majority and overlooks socio-economic nuances. From a decolonial perspective [3, 10], the WEIRD-centricity is not merely a methodological oversight; it is a systemic issue. Still, it reflects a more profound power imbalance, where WEIRD perspectives, values, and designs, including those that embed DPs and predatory monetization, are often uncritically exported and imposed upon diverse global audiences. Novel DP cases in widely used apps in Brazil [9, 28], most of which were developed elsewhere, suggest that the context may enable new forms of exploitation. Is it purposeful or coincidental? Does it matter?

The creator-consumer divide can serve as a lens to examine both the impact of manipulative and exploitative game designs and monetization models on Global South markets, as well as the potential for a design considered safe in a WEIRD context to become harmful when deployed in a non-WEIRD one.

3 A Speculative Perspective: Helena and The Gilded Cage of *Ouroboros Seed*

This paper uses a speculative design extrapolation [12] to propose a critical future artifact and an imagined scenario that asks: ***What if the creator-consumer divide ensnares individuals in a cycle where virtual escape consumes real-world essentials and erodes civic integrity?***

Imagine Helena, an archetype of the systemic vulnerability previously described. Overwhelmed by the precarity of her life, she turns to her smartphone not just for distraction, but for the sense of control and achievement her reality denies her. She discovers Ouroboros Seed. Unlike the simple games she's used to, it is a polished title from a huge WEIRD-country-based studio, its ads promising a vibrant world of community and growth. She doesn't know that its state-of-the-art AI engine was prohibited in its home country for the invasive data extraction used to fuel in-game loops, nor that it was deployed in Brazil through regulatory arbitrage.

Initially, the game delivers. Its AI-optimized loops provide a comforting sense of progress, fostering a deep engagement that soon becomes dependency. The system then creates personalized crises that make progress dependent on either intense Grinding [38] or a $18 Pay-to-Skip offer. For Helena, $18 is not disposable income; it represents the portion of her monthly income for cooking gas. Her inability to pay is her only defense. But at an AI-calculated moment of peak desperation, the game presents a different kind of offer: the 'Community Solidarity Pledge.' It is not a demand for immediate cash, but a subtle prompt to pledge a portion of her upcoming government benefit, the Bolsa Família. Framed as a pro-social commitment, not a purchase, and designed to exploit the human bias for immediate relief over a future cost, the offer bypasses her financial barrier. She sacrifices a piece of her real-world safety net for a fleeting sense of success in her gilded cage.

But the exploitation does not end with her finances. The rich psychological profile the AI built on Helena, identifying her anxieties and moments of low cognitive resistance, is sold to political campaigns for targeted disinformation during a contentious local election, leveraging the same vulnerabilities the game monetized.

Artifact from the future: The *Adaptive Engagement & Resource Pathway Report* for Ouroboros Seed's developers (Annex A). The dashboard dehumanizes Helena, reducing her to a set of quantified vulnerabilities, such as being 92% Prone to 'reactive choices' in a 'Scarcity Context.' It logs triggers designed to weaponize psychological states like 'Scarcity + Anxiety' and details the harm as a 'Projected Redistribution' of resources from her specific urban district. The corporate euphemism calls a monetization push the 'Harvest Equinox' seasonal event, and classifies manipulative tactics as 'Narrative Anchors.' A final note confirms her profile matches a 'Civic Tier 2 pattern' and is flagged for a third-party messaging test cycle, pending a performative internal ethics review.

Critical Questions: How must HCI's definition of 'harm' in games evolve when designs prey not on universal biases, but on widespread, structural vulnerabilities? What are our distinct ethical duties when games are deployed not into isolated pockets of vulnerability, but into entire markets where these conditions are the norm? And when this results in a massive, unidirectional extraction of value from the Global South, regardless of intent, is it not our responsibility to name it for what it is: a new form of cognitive colonialism?

Ouroboro's speculative dystopia is a provocation. It aims to make palpable the extreme and deeply inequitable harms that can arise when the creator-consumer divide in gaming is pushed to its potential extreme.

4 Toward a Decolonial Game and Play Research

Rooted in my perspective as a researcher from Brazil, this paper used a speculative scenario to argue that the impact of deceptive design in games (and potentially other apps) is not uniform. The proposed theoretical construct, called the creator-consumer divide, illustrates how the most insidious harm occurs when sophisticated design exploits pre-existing, systemic vulnerabilities, preying on the educational deficits, economic precarity, and regulatory gaps

that societies like mine, mainly in the Global South, have already inflicted upon their citizens. Informed by decolonial thought, this vision challenges the HCI and games communities to reflect on when play becomes another frontier for extraction. This compels us to ask how we can move beyond studying non-WEIRD contexts as mere sources of data and toward building genuine, equitable partnerships with communities in the Global South. What are our responsibilities in co-creating research agendas and design paradigms that build resilience rather than deepen the precarity of the already vulnerable? It is not trivial. But ultimately, is the CHI PLAY community willing to try?

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A The Ouroboros Seed Developer Dashboard



Figure 1: The speculative dashboard for Ouroboro Seed's developers operationalizes the creator-consumer divide and illustrates how structural regulatory gaps (Nuance 2) enable a game to convert one's personal narrative of vulnerability (Nuance 1) into a clinical, real-time pathway for exploitation.